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1. Introduction

This guide is the help reference for the internal Proficiency Testing Laboratory Information Management System (PT-LIMS) application. It provides role-based guidance, step-by-step procedures, and system reference for managing customers, participants, schemes, distributions, results, assessment, test commentary, and publication.

Audience:

- System Administrators
- Scheme managers
- Packing and Shipping Team members
- Internal Users
- Test Commentators
- Assessors
- Those authorized to sign off results.

Purpose: Explain concepts, document page behaviour, and provide clear, actionable procedures.

Scope: Covers all components available via the left-hand side navigation bar for authorised users.

Key Roles (Summary)

Role	Information
Admin	System administration area.
Contracts Admin	Management of Customers, Participants and Contracts.
Scheme Admin	Management of Scheme templates.
Scheduling	Distribution scheduling and tabulation preparation.
Internal User	Distribution preparation, packaging, and results entry.
Test Commentator Note: this role is currently termed Test Consultant in the system.	Area for Test Commentators to provide commentary.

Assessor	Area for Assessors to enter assessment of samples.
Results Sign-Off	Authorising and publishing of Tabulations.
Support	Area for IT support to view error logs.

2. Global System Behaviour

Navigation & Home

- Home is the main landing page for the system and links to application areas based on the user's assigned roles. If no links are visible on the left navigation, roles have not been assigned—contact a System Administrator.

Audit Trail

- Certain objects cannot be changed without recording a reason for audit purposes. The Audit page provides a box to enter the reason for change prior to saving.
- The audit trails require other software, e.g. PowerBi, to visualize.

Errors & Access

Error Page

- Displayed when something goes wrong (e.g., invalid URL, lost database connection).
- Retry the action; if the problem persists, contact an administrator.

Page Not Found

- Shown when the requested page does not exist—most commonly due to an invalid URL.

Access Denied

- Shown when access to the requested page is restricted. To gain access, contact a System Administrator.

Printing & Label Help

- Ensure the printer is on and stocked with label media.
- If printing fails, power-cycle the printer.

- To use a different printer, reconfigure settings and raise a helpdesk call to complete the change.

Universal Search Patterns

- Search pages allow multi-field filtering. Supplying more fields narrows results, as criteria are combined (logical AND).

3. System Administration

Overview

- Administers users, roles, and system-wide settings. Users are located via Active Directory (AD) search and then assigned system roles to grant access.

Manage Roles

- The page lists each user with checkboxes for roles. Tick/untick and Save to change access. Users in Scheduling or Internal User roles get access to shared distribution pages, searches, and label printing.
- You cannot remove yourself from the Admin role.
- Adding a user to Test Consultant role enables setting their department on the Test Consultant Department page.

Create User

- Use the search box to find the user in AD by Login (e.g., m123456), Forename, or Surname.
- Select the desired user from the dropdown results and create the account.
- New users have no roles by default; use Manage Roles to assign.
- Only users with an email address in AD can be added (the system uses email for communication).

Remove User

- Use the dropdown list of current system users.
- Select the user and click Remove User to revoke access.
- Internal Test Consultant Department
- Edit the Department that appears after the consultant's name on Tabulations.
- To deactivate a consultant, toggle Active to inactive. This prevents assignment to schemes and disables duties.

Manage External Test Consultants

- Each external Test Consultant requires Name and Email (Department is optional).
- A “Generate Login” link appears when a login has not been created yet (available after saving the consultant).
- Toggle Active to inactive to prevent new assignments and duties.

Manage Viewers

- Each Viewer requires Name and Email.
- Generate Login is available after the viewer record is saved.

Manage Countries

- View and edit the list of available countries used by Customers, Participants, and Group Addresses.
- Countries can only be removed if not referenced by any of these entities.
- Editing a country updates it everywhere it is used.

External Site Management

- Further Information message: Text displayed on the external website’s “Further Information” screen.
- Important message: Text displayed on the external website home page for urgent notices.
- Error screen email address: The contact address for Vetqas to receive queries.

Administration Charges

- Store the standard Administration Charge for setting up a new Contract for each system currency.
- On new contracts this value defaults from System Administration (based on the customer’s currency) but can be overridden for discounts.

Weighted Pricing Plan

- Configure annual weighted pricing percentages. Columns represent selected number of distributions by a participant; rows represent total distributions available on a scheme. Use the Financial Year dropdown to switch year.
- Contract item price = accumulative percentage × scheme price.
- Renew the plan for the next financial year using the link under the table (available only for the next year and typically from 1 April).

4. Contracts Management

Overview

- Manage Customers (organisations/labs/groups), Participants (labs performing tests), Contracts (typically annual), and Contract Items (Participant × Scheme with pricing and distribution selections).
- Contracts can be merged and renewed at year end; additional contracts can start mid-year.
- When adding an additional contract, enter the suffix number manually.

Customers

- Lists all customers.

Create Customer / Customer Details

- QAL number and Name are required. QAL is generated on first save.
- Initial Start Date is read-only and records when the customer was first saved.
- Currency determines the currency for all Contract Items.
- Active status: To set a customer inactive, all child participants must first be inactive. Use the “Is Active?” checkbox.
- Inactive reason: Indicate “Inactive – error” to identify customers created in error (for reporting).
- Comments are internal; Postage Arrangements appear on packing lists in Distributions.
- Print Label buttons create address labels (see [Printing Help](#) if errors occur).

Participants

- Lists all Participants for the current Customer. Once created, an External Login can be generated for access to the external website. “Details” shows participant details; “Viewers” assigns viewers.

Create Participant / Participant Details

- Lab Code: Unique laboratory identifier. Changing the code shows a warning; previous codes are kept for history.
- Lab Name: Internal description; not printed on paperwork or labels.
- Active status: Controls visibility in Contract Item selection. Inactive labs do not appear.
- Inactive reason: Mark whether inactive is genuine or created-in-error for reporting.

- Other Packing Requirements: Displays on packing lists.
- Copy from Customer Contact: Copies the customer address fields.
- Group Address: Use “Select a Group Address” to assign or “Clear Group Address” to remove.
- Print Address Label: Prints a label (see Printing Help if errors occur).

Viewers (Participant)

- Assign viewers to a participant to allow access to Tabulations for distributions in which the participant took part.
- Tabulations shown to a viewer are filtered to only participants to which they have been assigned.

Contracts

- First table: Contracts for Current or Next year.
- Second table: Old (read-only) contracts.
- Inactive contracts are shown struck-through.
- Three export links allow single exports for mail-merges (see Exports section).

Import Permits link per contract records permit receipt and expiry.

Create Contract / Contract Details

- Contract Type: UT suggests UT3/306 as Contract Number; FT allows free choice.
- Commencement Date is read-only and records when the contract was first entered.
- Administration Charge defaults from System Admin but can be changed (e.g., group discounts).
- Contract currency is inherited from the Customer.

Renew Contracts

- Available only if contracts exist for Current year and none for Next year.
- Table 1: Select which Current-year contracts to merge (Inactive contracts default to unticked).
- Selection of a new Contract Signatory is optional.
- Table 2: Combined list of Contract Items—select which items move to the new contract.
- Items for schemes not renewed cannot be added to the new contract.

Contract Items

- Each item represents a Participant on a Scheme with a number of scheduled distributions.
- Removed items display with strike-through (viewable, read-only).
- If weighted pricing plan is set for the financial year, three pricing plans may apply: Full scheme, Weighted, Pro rata.
- Full scheme pricing: Used when all distributions are selected or the scheme is “As Available”. Price = scheme price.
- Weighted pricing: Default when a reduced number of distributions are selected. Price = accumulative % × scheme price.
- If a participant joins mid-year and selects all remaining distributions, either Weighted or Pro rata may apply—select from the dropdown.
- If no weighted table match exists, Pro rata applies: (scheme price / scheduled distributions) × distributions selected.
- Non-Fee Paying items have no price.
- Discount applies to items only (excludes postage).

Add Contract Item / Contract Item Details

- Select Scheme from the table (shows all schemes for the contract year).
- Select Participant from the Active participants dropdown.
- After selecting scheme, the months table displays scheduled months. All possible months default to ticked; others cannot be ticked.
- If a distribution is already distributed, its checkbox is disabled.
- To include a participant on a redistribution (ad-hoc), use the “Override” button to create a retrospective order for a previously active month (use only for ad-hoc redistributions).
- If a distribution has been initialised but not distributed, changes show a warning—confirm with packing team that it’s not too late to add/remove.
- External Reference is shown on tabulations when “Use External Reference” is enabled (optional; may be blank).
- Import/Export and Customs checkboxes add reminders to packaging sheets.
- Non-Fee Paying negates the scheme cost for this item.
- For schemes requiring data-sharing consent, a consent checkbox must be ticked before adding the contract item. The user creating the order must obtain participant consent (verbal or written).
- Other Packing Requirements display on packing lists.

Import Permits

- Record whether an Import Permit is required for each scheme and lab as indicated at contract creation (external or internal site).
- Record permit receipt and expiry date to drive automated reminders.

Search (Contracts)

- Customer search by Account Number, QAL Number, Name, Contact Name, Organisation, Country.
- Participant search by Lab Code, Lab Name, Contact Name.
- Supplying more data refines results (criteria are combined).

Group Addresses

- Use for multiple participants sharing a delivery address or redistribution hub (e.g., Finnish laboratories).
- Supports combined packaging to save shipping costs.
- Table lists all group addresses.
- Create / Edit Group Address
- Identifier: internal name for quick identification.
- Packing Instructions: appear on packing sheets in Distributions.

Exports

- Four export utilities generate mail-merged .doc documents from server-side templates. Upload templates must include the mail-merge field names. All templates share a single server folder, so filenames must be unique across all four exports.

Export Contracts

- Export all contracts for all customers in all years. Single-contract export is also available from the Contracts page.

Export Job Sheets

- Export all job sheets for all customers in all years. Single job sheet export is available from the Contracts page.

Export Renewal Letters

- Export renewal letters for all customers with a Current-year contract. Filter by UK or Non-UK.
- Export Address Confirmation Letters
- Export address confirmation letters for all customers for the current year. Single-letter export available from the Contracts page.

5. Schemes Management

Overview

- Manage scheme templates, tests, result items, method items, category items, criterion items, distribution cycles, pricing, and tabulations.
- Edits to tests or tabulations set a new Version Date. Changes apply to future distributions, starting from the next scheduled distribution after the edit.

Schemes List

- Shows schemes setup for Current and Next year. The History link shows all years the scheme has run.

Create Scheme / Scheme Details

- Use tabs to configure details, tests, distribution-level data, results tabulations, test consultants, assessors, and viewers.

Scheme Tabs

Tab	Functionality
Details	Distribution cycle, price, and core settings.
Tests	Define Tests, Result Items, Method Items, and, if applicable, Category and Criterion Items.
Distribution Level Data	Information shown on Results Entry forms.
Results Tabulations	Tabulations and settings required for results processing.
Test Consultants	Assign consultants to provide commentary (hidden if assessment is required).
Assessors	Assign assessors to enter assessment (hidden if assessment is not required).

Viewers	Assign viewers who can see tabulations.
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- PT Numbers are not required to be unique, but the system warns on reuse.
- Distribution months: tick one or more months, or tick “As Available”. “As Available” schemes appear in each month’s Scheduling list but must be “Commenced” to run in a month.
- Months already initialised have disabled checkboxes.
- Combined Packaging: mark schemes that can be packed with others; week number is set to 1 so they ship together.
- Data Consent Declaration: For schemes needing participant consent for data use/sharing, populate declaration text. It is shown on the external site during ordering and must be acknowledged before an order can be placed.
- Assessment setting: A scheme either requires assessment or not. This can only be set during scheme creation. Assessment-required schemes allow category/criterion items on tests; non-assessment schemes cannot use category/criterion items.
- If the scheme requires assessment, select at least two assessors; the Test Consultant tab is hidden. If the scheme does not require assessment, select a test consultant; the Assessor tab is hidden.
- Adding tests/items: dropdowns display items available in the scheme’s year. Reorder tests and items using up/down arrows.
- Tabulations (no assessment): define at least two tabulations: one “Test Consultant’s Tabulation” and at least one for Sign-Off (e.g., lab issue tabulation).
- Tabulations (assessment): only one tabulation is required.
- Intended Results Only tabulations show no participant rows.
- Single Participant Tabulations show only one participant’s results and are only available to that participant.
- Show Ratings will include score tables on tabulations and auto-enables “Score Samples”.
- Availability: choose whether tabulation is visible to Participants, Viewers (and Test Consultants), or Both.
- Use External Reference displays the Contract Item External Reference instead of Lab Code on tabulations.

- Viewers tab: assign viewers to the scheme to see tabulations for all its distributions.

Printable Schemes

- Lists all schemes for Current and Next year in a printable layout.

Printable Scheme (Mock Results Entry Form)

- Print a mock-up of the Results Entry form for organisers before any distribution is initialised.

Sample numbers display with dummy values.

Search (Schemes)

- Search schemes by name (full or partial).

Test Types

- Defines available Test Types for a given year.
- Test Types in use on any scheme cannot be edited/removed; attempting to do so lists the schemes using them.
- Test Types persist year to year (Current-year definitions are available for Next year).

Test Result Items

- Defines available Test Result Item Types for a given year.
- Items in use cannot be edited/removed; attempting to do so lists schemes using them.
- Result Item Types persist year to year.
- Return Types define input formats:
- Slash-separated options (e.g., yes/no) render as dropdowns.
- Numeric like 999.99: values 0–999 with up to two decimals.
- A(12) or X(12): text with maximum length; X(lots) ~8000 characters.

Test Method Items

- Defines available Test Method Item Types for a given year.
- Items in use cannot be edited/removed; attempting to do so lists schemes using them.
- Method Item Types persist year to year.
- Return Types mirror those of result items (dropdowns, numeric, text with length limits).

Category Items

- Defines available Category Items for a given year.
- Items in use cannot be edited/removed; attempting to do so lists schemes using them.
- Category Items persist year to year.

Criterion Items

- Defines available Criterion Items for a given year.
- Items in use cannot be edited/removed; attempting to do so lists schemes using them.
- Criterion Items persist year to year.

6. Distributions

Overview & Stages

- The monthly distribution cycle comprises five stages: Scheduling, Preparation, Packaging, Results, and Tabulations.
- The “Initialise This Month” link (Scheduling role only) starts scheduling for the next month, creating distributions and suggesting UK/Overseas posting dates, deadlines, and results issue targets.
- Once initialised, scheme selection for that month cannot change, but participants can be added/removed until posting.
- Stage progress bars show completion across distributions.

Stage	Description
Scheduling	Manage dates, commence/cancel distributions, set sample information and intended results.
Preparation	Track sample preparation and print results entry forms.
Packaging	Lists distributions with posting dates and records packing/posting.
Results	Monitor returned results and enter postal submissions.

Tabulations	Amend results, gather Test Consultant comments or Assessment, and send for Results Sign-Off.
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Participant Address Labels

- Use search filters to locate the participant.
- Print the label. If errors occur, see Printing Help.

Group Address Labels

- Print single Group Address labels as required.
- If printing errors occur, see [Printing Help](#).

Search (Distributions)

- Search by Distribution Number or Sample Number to locate a scheme/distribution.

Monthly Distributions

- View schemes with a distribution in the selected month.
- Left-side dates (per scheme): UK Distribution, Overseas Posting (combined packaging only), Results Receipt Deadline, Results Issue Target.
- Links per scheme:
- Define/View Sample Numbers: Enter sample information and allocation.
- View Intended Results: Enter any known intended results prior to receipt.
- Commence Distribution / Cancel Distribution: For “As Available” schemes, commence once stock is ready; cancel any time if needed.
- View Participants: Manage repeat distributions and modify participant deadline dates.

Distribution Participants

- Shows all participants on the distribution.
- Repeat this Distribution: Select some or all participants to receive a repeat distribution. Use the select-all checkbox to quickly select all.
- To include a new participant not in the original run for ad-hoc samples, first create a retrospective order using the Contract Item “Override” button; they will then appear here for repeating.
- Change Deadline Date: Modify individual participant deadlines.

Sample Numbers

- For each sample, enter the Internal Description (mandatory). This is used internally during Preparation and is not visible externally.
- Tabulation Description is shown as the intended result description on tabulations.
- Expand rows to edit Test Instruction (appears on entry forms) and Description for TC (background for consultants). Both optional.
- Required quantity is calculated by summing requested sets across participants (useful for deciding whether to commence “As Available” schemes).
- Sample Allocation: un-tick to assign specific samples to specific tests (e.g., for microbiology, allocate gram-positive/negative appropriately).
- For assessment-required schemes, samples are unallocated by default—tick to allocate.

Intended Results

- Enter any intended results known before participant results are received.
- All fields are optional but must match each item’s return format.
- Tick “range” to specify lower/upper acceptable values; labs still see a single entry field.
- Sample Preparation
- Print preparation lists with expandable per-sample information.
- Track three stages: Diary Entry, Preparation Started, Preparation Complete (indicates samples labelled into sets ready for packing). Clicking a later stage auto-completes earlier stages with current date.
- Cannot start preparation until sample numbers are defined in Scheduling.
- Use subset tick-boxes to print partial lists; printable version auto-expands sample info for selected schemes.
- Links provide blank printable results entry forms.

Printable Results Reporting Form

- From a dropdown, print a blank form or a form including intended results.

Sample Packaging

- Three packaging sheets:
- Group Address Packaging: Participants with Group Address on Combined Packaging schemes.
- Participant Combined Packaging: Participants without Group Address on Combined Packaging schemes.

- Daily Packaging: Participants on non-Combined Packaging schemes with posting dates.
- Each list displays packing information with tick-boxes for Packed and Posted (replaced by current date when ticked).
- Print full or partial lists using the Print column.
- Daily Packaging highlights items due for posting.
- Print Labels uses the same selection as Print and prints appropriate labels. If errors occur, see Printing Help.
- Print Customs (on Participant Combined and Daily Packaging): downloads Word pro forma invoices; save locally or to SharePoint and attach to parcels.

Results Receipt

- Shows participant progress entering results online.
- Allows staff to input posted results on behalf of participants.
- For assessment-required schemes, manage receipt of samples from participants.
- Row expansion shows participants; tick-box indicates additional documents returned (passed to Test Consultants). First Edit/Last Edit show data entry progress.

Sample Receipt (Assessment)

- Lists allocated samples per test for a participant on a distribution.
- Per-sample options: Submitted to QAU / Not Submitted / Not in repertoire. Select via checkboxes.

Results

- View participant results.
- Enter results received by post.
- Do not use this page for internal “tidying up”. Use Amend Results to preserve originally submitted data.
- No results can be entered after the deadline date.

Tabulations

- Open the named tabulation ("TC" marked items indicate the Test Consultant tabulation).
- Issued link shows published versions and how many times issued.
- Workflow links under Amend Results depend on scheme type:
- If scheme does not require assessment

- Send To Test Consultant: emails the primary consultant and allows all scheme consultants to see results; link changes to First Email Sent.
- After 7 days without comments, chaser email is sent; link shows Chaser Email Sent.
- After 9 days without comments, link shows Overdue and allows staff to enter a note such as “No Test Consultant comments provided”.
- If comments are provided, link shows View Comments to review/edit.
- If comments are not required and distribution is sent for Sign-Off, link displays No Comments.
- If scheme requires assessment
- Send For Assessment: enables assessors to enter and submit scores/comments.
- Send for Results Sign-Off: makes the distribution visible to Authorisers; link shows Waiting for Sign-Off until each tabulation is Issued or rejected.
- If tabulations are not issued by the Results Issue Target Date, link shows Overdue.
- After completion, link changes to Re-Send for Results Sign-Off to allow republication if needed.

Tabulation (Draft)

- Read-only printable view of the draft tabulation for pre–sign-off checks.

Issued Tabulations & History

- Table lists all issued versions with the signatory responsible.
- Issued Tabulation page provides a read-only printable view.

Assessment Results (Analytics)

- Displays a bar chart of the frequency of overall assessment scores for a test.

Amend Results

- Enter intended results calculated from participant results and tidy participant data while preserving original submissions.
- Edit any cell by double-clicking. Nil Return rows are greyed; double-click to add a comment.
- Range tick-boxes indicate intended result ranges.
- If scoring is enabled, enter per-participant per-sample scores. Scores can be entered before or after sending to the Test Consultant.

View Comments

- Review Test Consultant (or QAU staff) comments; add or amend as needed.
- Attach a single file to the tabulation record as supporting evidence.

7. Test Consultant Module

Overview

- Shows distributions for the selected year where the user is a Test Consultant.
- Each distribution indicates whether comments are required or can be viewed (historical).

Test Consultant Tabulation

- Three tabs provide: (1) the tabulation to comment on, (2) full results (all result/method items and helpful participant info), and (3) detailed sample information when available.
- Filter samples from the tabulation using checkboxes; click Draw Tabulation to refresh.
- Export full tabulation to Excel.
- Save to retain draft comments; use Save and Submit when finished—submitted comments cannot be changed.

8. Assessor Module

Overview

- Shows distributions ready for assessment or already assessed for the selected year where the user is an Assessor.
- Displays associated tests; use View beside each test to open assessment items.
- Indicates whether assessment has been submitted per test. Assessment is complete only when all tests are submitted.

Assessment Items

- Displays a table per sample with a row per participant who submitted a sample to QAU. Identities are anonymised by lab code.

- Participants on the scheme who did not submit or who do not have the test are not listed.
- Indicators show which items have saved assessment. Use View/Edit to open Assessment Entry.
- Click Submit when all items are assessed. A confirmation appears; a warning is shown if not all items are assessed (submission still allowed in cases such as unassessable samples).
- After submission, the page shows the assessor identity and timestamp. No further changes are possible.

Assessment Entry

- Top section (if present) lists the participant's result items; assessors may review context.
- Each category item lists associated criteria with checkboxes; enter category scores (1–5).
- Enter an overall sample score and optional comment.
- If assessment has been submitted for the test, the entry is read-only.

8. Results Sign-Off

Overview

- Expandable list of tabulations ready for sign-off. Numbers in brackets indicate how many times a tabulation has previously been issued.
- Displays whether the tabulation is a Single Participant Tabulation and its audience (Participants, Viewers, or Both).

Tabulation for Publication

- Review the final draft tabulation and any uploaded supporting files.
- Authorise to publish or Reject to return for amendments. Rejected tabulations restart the tabulation cycle for necessary changes.

Assessment Results (Analytics)

- Shows a bar chart of overall assessment score frequency for a test (same analytics as in Distributions).